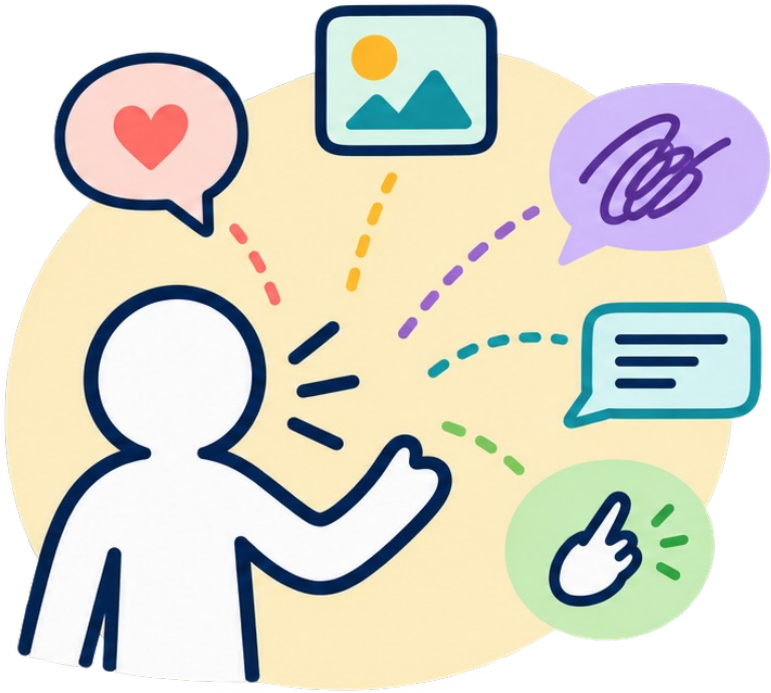




Secondary Education · Session 3

Autistic Experience at Secondary School:

**Communication, Connection
and Identity**



Communication





Understanding and expressing

How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.

Understanding

Information coming in

Spoken words



Visual or written



Demonstration



Gesture and context



Expressing

Messages going out

Speech



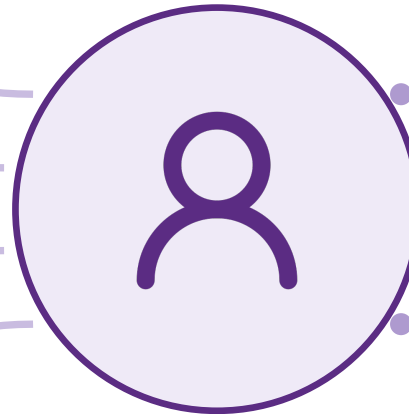
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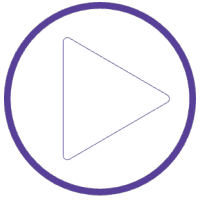


Writing or typing



Gesture, sign and movement





Communication experiences

What stood out to you about what supported communication?



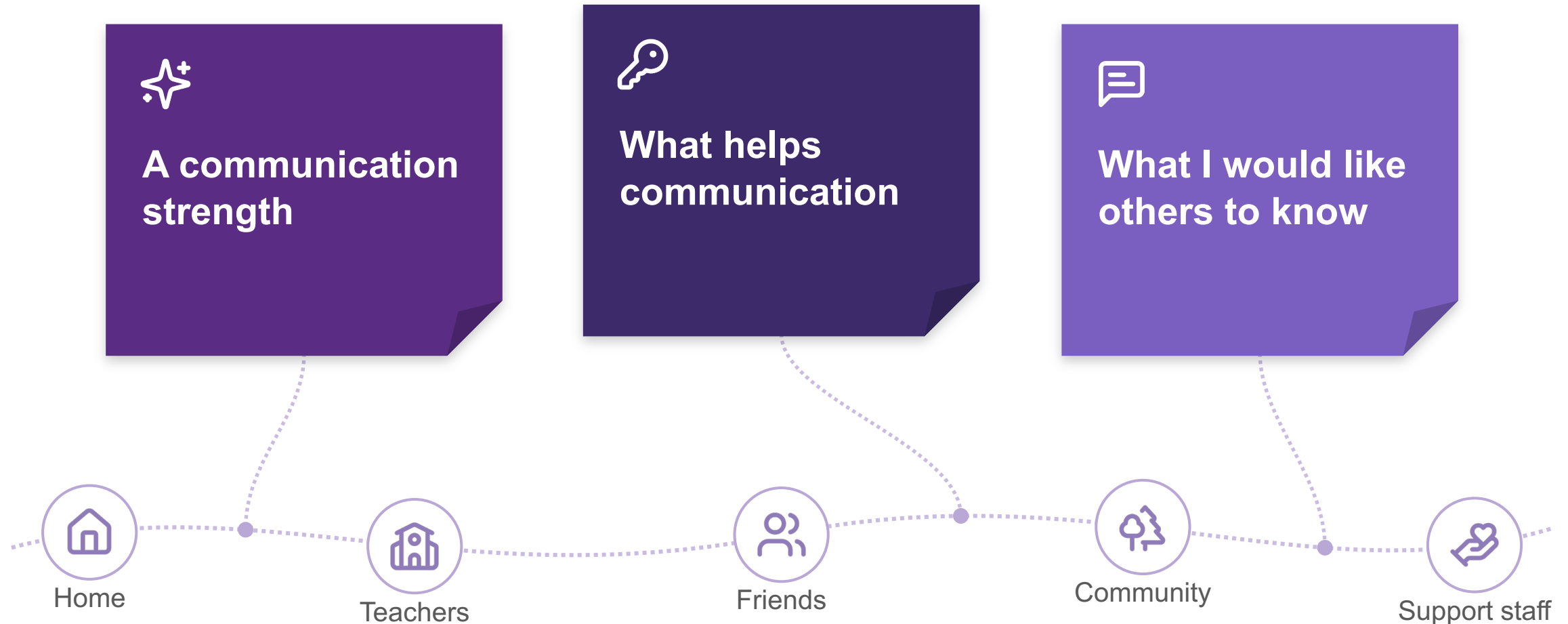
Who is part of the communication network?



Add one person or place.

You can return to the rest later.

What should travel between people and places?



How can we support communication?

1

CLEAR COMMUNICATION

Use familiar words.
One idea or step at a time.

2

PROCESSING TIME

Pause. Give time to
understand and respond.

3

VISUAL SUPPORTS

Show information as well
as saying it.

The right support depends on the person and the moment.

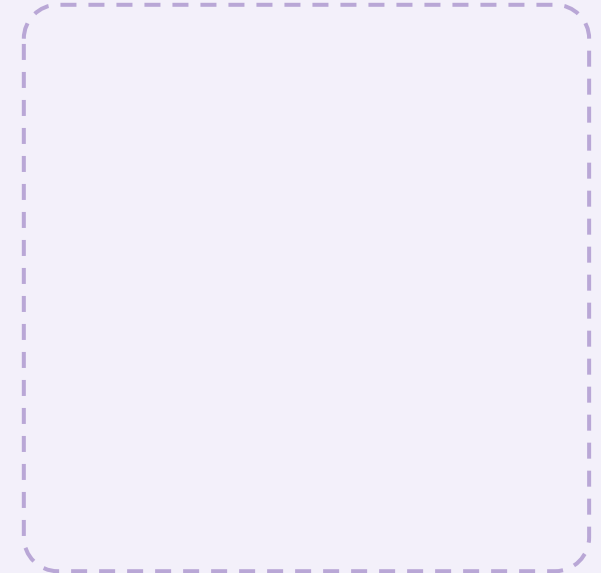
What are visual supports?



How much time is left?



What do I do next?

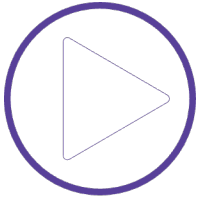


What is happening today?

Information you can see and come back to.

Double Empathy





Being social



Social Interactions

Family

School

Community

Online

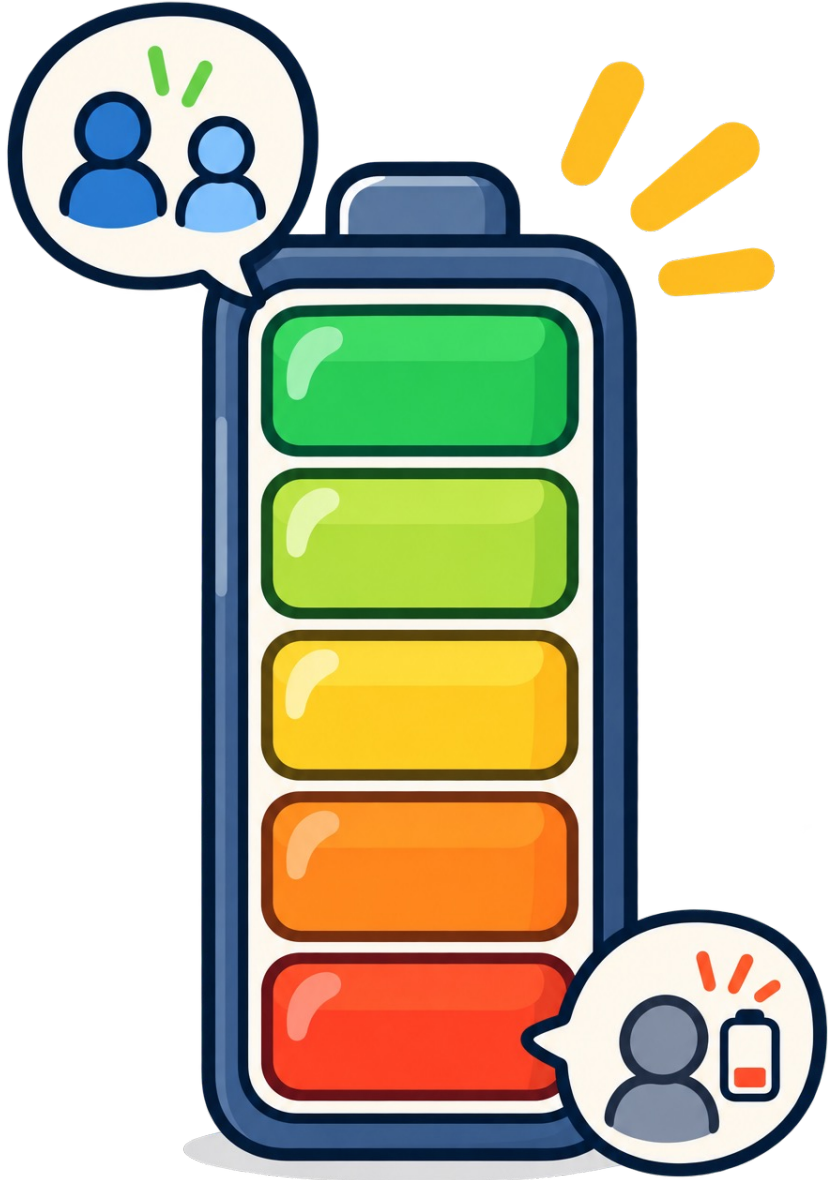


Discussion activity



- Where do the students you have in mind spend recess and lunch, and who with?
- What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy?
(Shared interests, gaming, sport, music, clubs, online communities, being together quietly?)
- Which parts of the day are socially hardest for them: group work, corridors, the canteen, PE?
- What could teachers change to make connection easier, without putting them on the spot?





Managing Daily Capacity

Batteries and Spoons

Think of a student's energy as a battery.

Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day.

Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, it may show, or it may be hidden.



Fluctuating Capacity



Six classrooms, six teachers, one student

Every period change brings a new room, a new adult, new expectations and a new sensory setting.

Each teacher sees one part of the day

and little of what has built up before they arrive.

What works in period 1 may be unknown in period 4

unless something carries it across the timetable.

Sharing what works

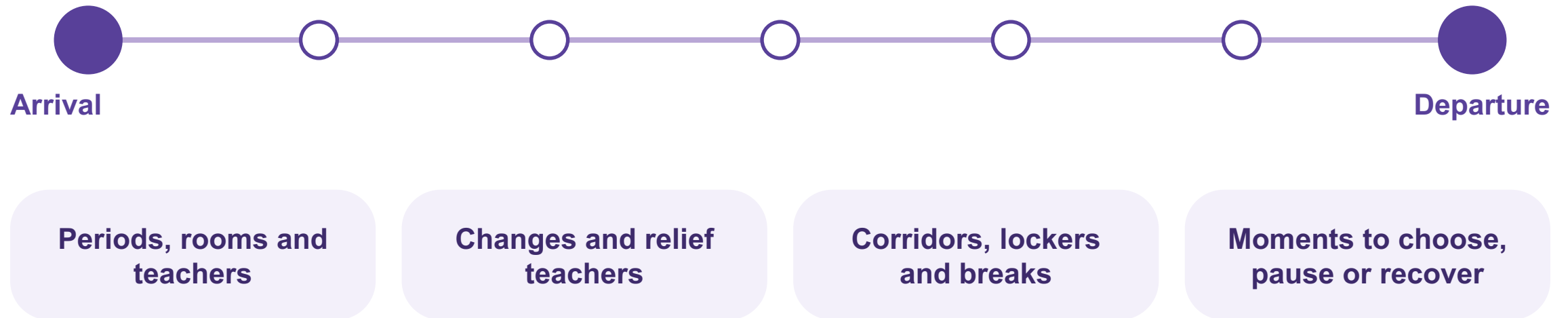
is something a school can plan for. Session 4 comes back to this.

How many rooms, teachers and corridor trips are in one student's day?

Map a secondary school day

Use a real timetable for one of your students, or the sample Year 9 timetable.

Go period by period. For each student, note what the period asks of them and whether anything gives energy back.



What costs? What lightens?

Return to the day map.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand?

What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Record questions rather than claiming to know an internal state.

The school-day stack

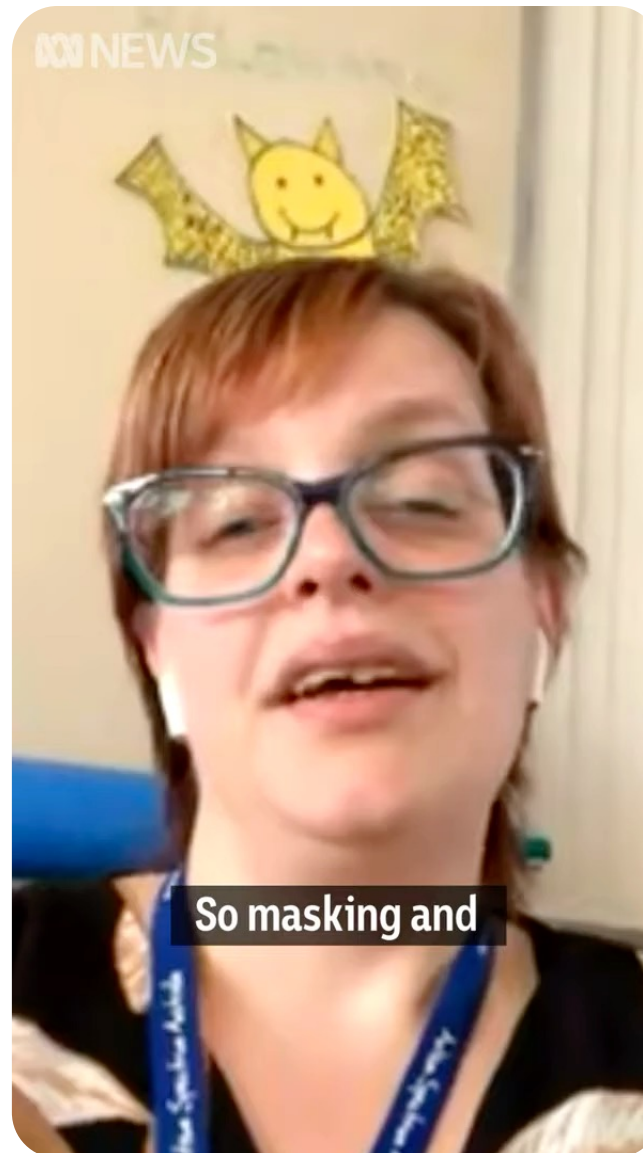
Notice what accumulates across the whole day.

A moment that seems small in isolation may sit within many demands. Include supports, relief and recovery as well as cost.





Masking



Masking and the cost of appearing fine



Masking in the teenage years

The pressure to fit in is often highest in the secondary years.

Masking often increases

as fitting in with peers matters more.

Working out who you are

while hiding parts of yourself takes a lot of energy.

Burnout and School Can't

can build up over the secondary years.

A time of growth

Young people can build self-understanding and self-advocacy when school feels safe.

Feeling safe to be themselves helps young people speak up for what they need.

“Good and chilled in class”

The quiet student who never causes trouble may be working harder than anyone in the room. Calm does not always mean okay. Sometimes it is masking.

Discussion activity



- Which classes, teachers or times of day ask the most of them to appear “fine”?
- Where at school do they seem most able to be themselves?
- Who would notice if they were struggling, and how would that reach the right people?

Audit the secondary day

Choose one part of the day that runs across classes. What may its impact be, and why?

- 1 Name the setting or process.
- 2 Write what educators can observe without interpretation.
- 3 List possible environmental or task contributors.
- 4 Record what lightens demand and one question to investigate.

Choose one to audit:

How instructions are given · assessment notice · corridors and lockers · relief-teacher arrangements · where a student can regulate between periods.

Carry into design

Choose a clear focus for the next session.

Keep

One practice to keep
because it supports
access, connection or
joy

Reduce

One barrier or
unnecessary demand to
reduce

Explore

One question to explore
with students, families
or the team

Keep students first.

Positive Autistic Identity

A young person who knows who they are - and feels genuinely valued for it - has more available for everything else.

